

Episode 22: Once Upon a Time... (17) *Saint Seiya* Part 4 – The Story of Babel's Flame

I injured my back last weekend. The pain didn't recede but spread throughout my shoulder and worsened considerably (cries). So I went to a nearby orthopaedic clinic.

After examination and looking at X-rays, the doctor's diagnosis...

"We can't rule out suspicion of 'cervical hernia,' but well, it's probably 'frozen shoulder.'"

Sigh...

After examination, I had various consultations with a physical therapist. Just from 2-3 body tilt and muscle tests, man, they perfectly diagnosed my work posture! Amazing insight.

In my case, I extend my right hand to operate the keyboard while working with a tablet in my left hand. Maintaining that posture for long periods causes excessive tension in right shoulder to back muscles, worsening with "frozen shoulder" around the shoulder joint area.

Infrared treatment to warm and loosen shoulder-to-back muscles, neck traction and stretching, lying on mats for stretching, electrode electrical therapy, and done.

So for a while, it's rehabilitation (cries).

Well then.

Saint Seiya, which had left my hands after just Episode 1, returned to me after half a year.

This year, Toei Doga decided to order some TV production that had been done domestically to Taiwanese production companies. While "collaborative" works had long sent animation and finishing, plus some key animation, to overseas production companies, ordering domestic TV works overseas was the first time since I joined Toei Doga. So for overseas-ordered episodes only, I would handle colour direction and inspection.

Saint Seiya after half a year. Far from Morishita-san's "prophecy," it had become very popular with good ratings (bitter laugh). It was safely continuing beyond 2 cours.

Episode 26 at the end of that 2nd cour: "Friend or Foe Steel Saints." This episode became the first overseas order. The "Steel Saints" episode I wrote about last time.

Ordering to Taiwanese companies basically meant key animation and animation directors remained Japanese domestic staff, with animation and finishing requested from them. Rather than requesting all checks from them, Toei Doga sent assistant directors to their companies for animation delivery direction checks. Well, this was almost the same system as "collaborative" works. The difference was having that company handle 100% of the assigned episodes.

Moreover, since they weren't particularly experienced companies, animation was guided to some extent by assistant directors sent there, and finishing was guided by staff from certain finishing studios on long-term business trips.

So, Episode 26.

The story continued from the previous episode - the first half A-part was battles between **Babel**, the Silver Saint who manipulates flame, and Seiya's group. The second half B-part introduced Steel Saints and them heading somewhere by plane and being shot down (?), something like that I think.

The second half B-part wasn't much honestly, but *Seiya's* selling point was battle scenes. Using various photography processing to aim for things was one of this director's specialties. Moreover, since it was a Saint's technique manipulating flame, naturally we'd use lots of transmitted light masks to create "flame" effects.

During the story, Babel torments *Seiya* and friends with flame balls, and from one animation drawing of that flame ball, we decided to create 6 transmitted light masks for multiple photography of 3 types of flame light. Besides the painted cel of the flame ball itself, 6 masks (laughs). Finishing sheet count exploded! We ran out of BL (black) paint for painting transmitted light masks and had to urgently send additional supplies from Japan.

Furthermore, I proposed that when creating flame balls, naturally flame reflection would be needed, and we increasingly used overlaps from normal cels to reflection colour-change cels within single cuts. Not just Babel who manipulates flame, but *Seiya* and friends receiving those techniques also had 2 colour types of cels made for overlaps. Plus, **Cygnus's** "cooling technique" colour-change overlaps to protect from that heat were naturally done. Furthermore, Steel Saints' techniques appearing to rescue *Seiya* and friends all similarly did various things.

With storyboards by this director who excels at battle direction, naturally animators put in effort. Animation sheet count naturally increased too (laughs). Thus, for one TV episode, it became work with terrifyingly excessive animation and finishing sheet counts.

I can say now - both I and the director were half deliberate criminals (laughs).

This overseas ordering system for producing domestic works is now done by every production company - so-called "normal thing" - but back then at Toei Doga, honestly we staff had mental resistance. Moreover, why order popular *Saint Seiya* overseas?

With such feelings, somehow we staff under direction felt a strange emotional uplift: "Let's make everyone say 'Wow!' anyway!"

Thus Episode 26 was completed with greatly excessive sheet counts and schedule. I don't know how it looked from outside (laughs), but for us it became a very well-made episode we could proudly say "How about that!"

Incidentally, we were properly scolded by production department higher-ups (laughs).

The storyboard and direction for this episode was by **Yamauchi Shigeyasu**. Thus began my days with Yamauchi-san.

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